

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Energy and Utilities English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For utility operations staff, energy project managers, grid planners, field supervisors, regulatory affairs teams, renewable-energy developers, customer operations teams, and infrastructure leaders.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

asset management

Planning and managing assets through their useful lives to support organizational objectives.

baseline

A defined starting value or agreed reference used to measure change.

capacity

Available people, assets, time, space, or system throughput for a given workload.

capital plan

A plan for investment in long-lived assets or major projects.

clearance

Formal permission or confirmation that a required review has been completed; the meaning depends on the task.

condition assessment

An evaluation of an asset's current physical or operating state.

crew staging

Positioning personnel and resources to prepare for an operational response.

critical customer

A customer whose service needs receive particular operational attention under defined criteria.

curtailment

A reduction in electricity generation or use required by operating conditions or instructions.

customer impact

The effect an event or decision has on people using a product or service.

demand response

A change in electricity use in response to prices, incentives, or system needs.

emergency response

Coordinated action under established procedures to address an urgent harmful event.

energize

To supply electrical energy to equipment or a circuit under the relevant authorized procedure.

failure rate

The frequency of failures relative to a defined operating time or population.

feeder

An electrical distribution circuit carrying power to a local service area.

incentive

A benefit or consequence intended to encourage particular behavior.

interconnection

A connection between an electricity-generating or storage facility and a power system.

lifecycle cost

The estimated costs of acquiring, operating, maintaining, and retiring an asset.

lockout

An authorized process using isolation and locking measures to control hazardous energy.

measurement and verification

Methods used to assess changes in performance or savings against a defined basis.

mutual aid

Assistance provided between organizations under agreed response arrangements.

prudence

Reasonableness of a utility decision or expenditure as assessed under the relevant regulatory standard.

queue

A list of items or people waiting for processing or service.

rate case

A regulatory proceeding concerning a utility's proposed rates and supporting basis.

reliability

The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time.

restoration

Returning a disrupted service to operation.

restoration priority

The order in which service-restoration activities are addressed under defined criteria.

SAIDI

System Average Interruption Duration Index: average interruption duration per customer under a stated reporting basis.

SAIFI

System Average Interruption Frequency Index: average number of interruptions per customer under a stated reporting basis.

switching order

An authorized sequence of electrical system operations; actual work must follow the approved procedure.

tariff

A published schedule of regulated service rates and conditions; in trade, a tax on specified goods.

vegetation management

Managing trees and other vegetation near utility assets under applicable operational and environmental requirements.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Grid Reliability and Outage Response

An outage update lists an affected area but the restoration estimate is still under assessment. A draft message gives a firm time.

The affected area is identified, but restoration timing is still being assessed. I'll state what is confirmed and when customers should expect the next update rather than promise an unverified time.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

02 | Safety, Field Work, and Switching

During a language simulation, two documents use different equipment identifiers for a field task. Only authorized procedures govern the actual work.

The equipment identifiers do not match. Please have the authorized team resolve the discrepancy using the approved procedure. I will repeat the identifiers clearly to confirm that we are discussing the same equipment.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

03 | Regulatory Affairs and Rate Cases

A customer sees a proposed rate adjustment and assumes it is already in effect. The notice describes a proposal under review.

The notice describes a proposed adjustment, not a change already in effect. Let me show you the stated review process and where to find the current applicable tariff information.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

04 | Renewables Integration and Interconnection

A project team describes an interconnection application as an approved connection. Technical and administrative reviews are still open.

The application has been submitted, but the reviews are still open. I'll describe the current stage and remaining steps without implying that connection has already been authorized.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

05 | Asset Management and Maintenance

Two asset options have different purchase prices and maintenance needs. A budget slide compares only the purchase price.

The initial price is only one part of the comparison. Let's show the assumed maintenance, expected service period, and other relevant lifecycle costs so the decision reflects the full basis of the estimate.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

06 | Emergency Preparedness and Storm Response

A storm-response coordination shift has several requested resources but only some confirmed. The next coordinator needs the distinction.

These resources are confirmed; the others are still requested. I've separated their status and contact points in the handoff. Please confirm receipt and update the record when an assignment changes.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

07 | Customer Programs and Energy Efficiency

An efficiency program reports lower energy use after installation, but weather and occupancy also changed.

Energy use fell after installation, but weather and occupancy changed too. I'll describe the measurement basis and remaining uncertainty before attributing the entire reduction to the program.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

08 | Executive Reliability and Investment Updates

A reliability presentation lists SAIDI and SAIFI without explanations. Community representatives need to understand the distinction.

One measure summarizes average interruption duration and the other interruption frequency for the defined customer group. I'll explain both, state the reporting basis, and show what changed over the period.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

GHG Protocol: corporate standard

<https://ghgprotocol.org/corporate-standard>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.